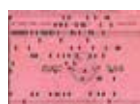
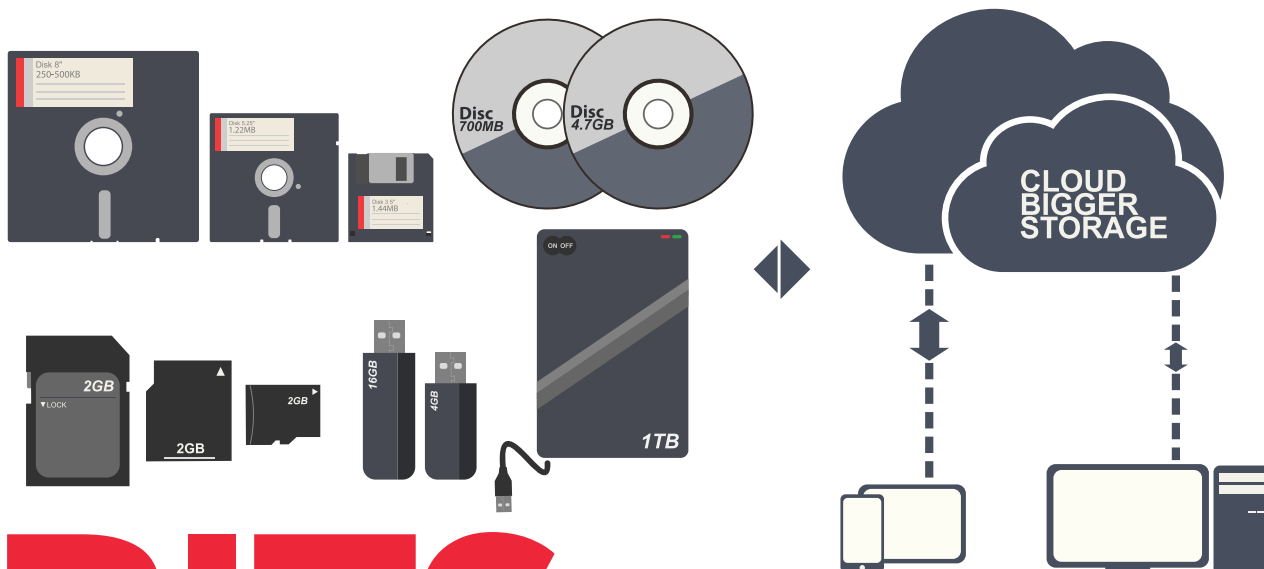
**Selectron tube**

At one time, cathode ray tubes that were used for television sets were actually turned into RAM. <https://digit.in/jul20-87>

**Punch cards**

This method of data storage predates digital computers, and was first used in the US census in 1890. <https://digit.in/jul20-88>



BITS & BYTES

The journey leading up to modern-day data storage

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We often take modern-day storage solutions for granted. They're seamless solutions that have become quite inexpensive and extremely efficient. However, they've come a long way from the early days of computing. In fact, it's not just the early years of computing that record data storage solutions. Data storage was practiced even by our prehistoric ancestors and the development of data storage along the centuries, aided by technological progress has

brought us where we are today. Let us take an in-depth look at the history of data storage.

DATA STORAGE HAD ITS ROOTS IN ANTIQUITY

People have been seeking ways to store information from the dawn of civilization to preserve their culture, innovations, and experiences. Pre-historic paintings, hieroglyphics in



Ancient medicinal practices were stored on papyrus in Egypt

ancient Egyptian pyramids, writings on bamboo stalks, and stone carvings and inscriptions were one of the earliest forms of data storage. In pre-historic times, red and yellow ochre, hematite, charcoal and manganese oxide was utilised to immortalise life events on rock walls, in caves and on ceilings. In India, people used palm leaves to preserve stories, legends, and other information. In 4000 BC, Sumerians drew their native script on clay tablets.

Papyrus, an early form of paper, was used in Ancient Egypt to store information. Paper was invented sometime between 200BC and 105AD and it greatly helped man's quest to document information. The usage of paper spread wildly from China to the Middle East to medieval Europe in the 13th century. In 1440 AD, the process of printing was invented by Gutenberg and this was yet another massive milestone in the history of data storage.

EARLY DAYS OF DATA STORAGE

Paper, incidentally, also contributed to the invention of the very first 'modern' form of data storage. Punch cards were the first effort at storing data in machine language. However, punch cards were used before computers were actually developed. They were utilised to convey information to